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THE BYLINE METHOD

The voice capture and ghostwriting framework — documented for the first time.

By MK Parrish

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WHY THIS EXISTS

Ghostwriting that works doesn't sound ghostwritten. It sounds like the person — on their best day, with an editor in their head. Most ghostwriting fails at exactly this point. It's competent and generic. It could be anyone. And the moment a reader thinks "this doesn't sound like them," the trust is gone.

The whole craft hinges on one thing nobody documents: how you *capture a voice* and then *write inside it* so faithfully that the person reads their own piece and says "that's exactly what I would have said — I just couldn't get it out."

The Byline is my done-for-you ghostwriting service. This is the method underneath it, written down for the first time. Use it to ghostwrite for someone else — a founder, an exec, a client. Or use it on *yourself*: to capture your own voice on a good day and write in it even when you're tired, rushed, or staring at a blank page.

The method runs in four parts: capture the voice, calibrate it across formats, write inside it, and keep the engine running with an editorial calendar. Start with capture — everything downstream depends on a voice you've actually pinned down.

PART 1 — THE VOICE-CAPTURE INTERVIEW

Voice doesn't live in a style guide. It lives in how a person actually talks when they forget they're being recorded. The interview's whole job is to get them talking like that, then mine the recording for the patterns.

Record it. Always. You're not listening for content — you're listening for *how they say things*. The transcript is the raw material.

The interview questions

Ask these in order. Let them ramble. The gold is usually in the tangent, not the answer.

WARM-UP (get them talking naturally)

- Tell me what you do, like you're explaining it to a friend at dinner.
- What's something in your field everyone believes that you think is wrong?
- What gets you fired up enough to rant about it?

VOICE PATTERNS (mine the how)

- What's a phrase you say all the time? Be honest, even if it's a tic.
- When you're explaining something hard, what do you compare it to?
- Are you a "let me be blunt" person or a "let me think out loud" person?

POINT OF VIEW (the spine of every piece)

- What's the hill you'll die on professionally?
- What advice do you give that people don't want to hear?
- What would you never say, even if it polled well?

STORIES (the proof and the texture)

- Tell me about a time you were completely wrong about something.
- What's the story you tell most often? Why that one?
- Who's the reader you're really writing for? Picture one person.

The voice profile — what to extract

After the interview, fill this from the transcript. This becomes the reference sheet you write against.

CADENCE: [short and punchy? long and winding? mixed?]

GO-TO PHRASES: [the actual words they repeat]

SENTENCE OPENERS THEY USE: [e.g. "Look," "Here's the thing," "Honestly"]

HUMOR: [dry? warm? none? self-deprecating?]

FORMALITY: [contractions? slang? swears? buttoned-up?]

METAPHOR SOURCE: [sports? cooking? machines? nature?]

HARD NO'S: [words/moves they'd never make]

THE POV: [the consistent point of view across answers]

THE READER: [the one person they picture]



Worked example — extracted profile

CADENCE: short, declarative, then one long aside. Talks in punches.

GO-TO PHRASES: "at the end of the day," "look," "that's the whole game"

OPENERS: "Look," "Here's what nobody tells you," "Real talk —"

HUMOR: dry, self-deprecating, occasional mild swear.

FORMALITY: heavy contractions, conversational, will say "damn."

METAPHOR SOURCE: poker and cooking.

HARD NO'S: "synergy," "thought leader," anything that sounds like

a LinkedIn guru. Won't humblebrag.

POV: "Most advice is for people who already made it. I write for

the ones still figuring it out."

READER: a 28-year-old freelancer one client away from quitting.



That profile is enough to write a hundred pieces that sound like this person. Without it, you're guessing.

PART 2 — THE TONE CALIBRATION GUIDE (ACROSS FORMATS)

Voice is constant. *Tone* shifts by format. The same person writes a LinkedIn post and a keynote and a client email differently — but it's still recognizably them. The skill is dialing tone up or down without losing the voice.

The calibration table

FORMAT	TONE DIAL	LENGTH	OPENING MOVE	WHAT STAYS CONSTANT
LinkedIn post	punchy, opinionated	short	hook line, stands alone	the POV, go-to phrases
Newsletter	warm, generous	medium	"you" focused, a story	cadence, humor
Keynote / talk	bold, performative	spoken	a question or a claim	the hill they die on
Client email	direct, warm	tight	the ask up front	contractions, plainness
Long essay	reflective, layered	long	a tension or a confession	the POV, the reader
Bio / profile	confident, compressed	very short	the one known-for thing	no humblebrag

The rule

Whatever the format, three things never move: **the point of view, the go-to cadence, and the hard no's**. Tone can flex loud or quiet. Those three are load-bearing — drop them and the voice breaks.

Worked example — one idea, three formats, one voice

THE IDEA: "Stop waiting until you're ready. You learn by shipping."

LINKEDIN (punchy):

Look — you're not going to feel ready. That feeling doesn't show up.

You learn the job by doing the job badly first. Ship the ugly version.

That's the whole game.

NEWSLETTER (warm):

Here's what nobody tells you when you start: the readiness never

arrives. I waited two years to "feel ready" to freelance. You know

what finally worked? Sending one bad pitch. Then another. You don't

think your way in — you ship your way in.

KEYNOTE (bold, spoken):

Raise your hand if you're waiting to feel ready. Keep it up. Now —

that feeling? It's not coming. I'm sorry. You learn this by doing

it badly in public first. So let's talk about how to ship ugly.



Same person every time. The "Look," the poker-flat cadence, the "that's the whole game" — all constant. Only the tone dial moved.

PART 3 — THE WRITING-IN-VOICE FRAMEWORK

Now you write. With the voice profile beside you, a draft becomes a controlled act, not a guess. Run this loop for any piece.

1. PICK THE POV ANGLE

What does THIS person uniquely think about the topic?

(Pull from the "hill they die on.") Not the topic – their take.

2. WRITE THE HOOK IN THEIR OPENER

Start with one of their actual sentence openers. Earn line two.

3. DRAFT FAST, IN CADENCE

Match their rhythm – short/long, punchy/winding. Don't edit yet.

If they talk in punches, write in punches.

4. SALT IN THE GO-TO PHRASES

Drop in 1-2 of their real phrases. Not every line – that's parody.

Just enough that an ear recognizes them.

5. RUN THE HARD-NO PASS

Delete anything on their banned list. This is where most ghostwriting gets caught — one "synergy" and it's blown.

6. THE MOUTH TEST

Read it aloud as them. Would they actually say this sentence?

Any line that fails, rewrite until it passes.

The "is it them?" checklist

- [] Opens in one of their real openers
- [] Cadence matches the profile (punchy/winding/mixed)
- [] 1-2 go-to phrases present, not overdone
- [] The POV is clearly *theirs*, not generic best-practice
- [] Zero banned words or moves
- [] Humor level matches (no jokes if they're dry; no stiffness if warm)
- [] Read aloud as them — every line passes the mouth test
- [] A person who knows them would say "yeah, that's them"

Worked example — same draft, fixed

GENERIC DRAFT (correct, but anyone could've written it):

"It's important to take action even when you don't feel fully prepared. Progress comes from doing, not waiting. Many successful people started before they were ready."

IN-VOICE REWRITE (profile applied):

"Look — you're not going to feel ready. I waited two years for that feeling and it never showed. You learn this by doing it badly first. Ship the ugly version. That's the whole game."

The first is a fortune cookie. The second is a specific human with a poker habit and a chip on their shoulder. Same advice. Only one has a pulse.

PART 4 — THE EDITORIAL CALENDAR

A voice is only worth capturing if you use it on a schedule. Sporadic genius loses to consistent presence. Here are the templates to keep the engine running.

The content pillars

Pick 3-4 themes the person owns. Everything they publish ladders to one.

PILLAR 1: _____ (their core POV)

PILLAR 2: _____ (a recurring topic they're known for)

PILLAR 3: _____ (the contrarian / spicy one)

PILLAR 4: _____ (the human / behind-the-scenes one)

The weekly calendar template

WEEK OF: _____

Day	Format	Pillar	Working title	Status
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Mon	LinkedIn			
Wed	Newsletter			
Fri	LinkedIn			

The idea bank

Never write from a blank page. Keep a running list, pulled straight from the interview transcript.

- Rants they went on (each = a post)
- Stories they told (each = a post or essay)
- "What nobody tells you about ___" (one per pillar)
- Hot takes / hills they'll die on
- Questions readers actually ask them



Worked example — a month, mapped

PILLARS: (1) ship before ready (2) freelance pricing
(3) why "thought leader" advice is broken (4) my own misses

Week	Mon (LI)	Wed (News)	Fri (LI)
1	Ship ugly (P1)	The 2-yr wait story	Pricing myth(P2)
2	Guru advice fails(P3)	What I got wrong (P4)	Ship ugly pt2
3	Raise your rates (P2)	A reader's question	Hot take (P3)
4	My worst pitch (P4)	Pricing breakdown(P2)	Recap / best-of

Every cell traces to a pillar, and every pillar traces to the interview. The calendar writes itself once the voice is captured.

THE BYLINE METHOD — ONE-PAGE RECAP

1. CAPTURE — interview, record, extract the voice profile
2. CALIBRATE — flex tone by format, keep POV + cadence + no's fixed
3. WRITE — POV angle → their opener → cadence → phrases → no-pass → mouth
4. SUSTAIN — pillars + weekly calendar + idea bank from the transcript



WHEN YOU WANT IT DONE FOR YOU

This is the method. Run it and you can write in a voice — yours or someone else's — that actually sounds like the person.

But capturing a voice and writing inside it for months is a craft *and* a time sink. The interview is the easy part. The hard part is the discipline: staying in voice across fifty pieces, never letting one "synergy" slip through, keeping the calendar full when the person is busy running their actual business. That's a job.

That's **The Byline** — the done-for-you version. I run the capture interview, build the voice profile, and ghostwrite on a calendar so the person shows up consistently, sounding exactly like themselves, without writing a word.

Find it at mkparrish.com.

It should sound like you. Let's make sure it does.

MK PARRISH